beyond it, mountains that stretch toward the horizon. From some points on the ranch, you can watch boats cruising across the Santa Barbara Channel, then turn your head and see the Santa Ynez Valley unfold like a huge wilderness amphitheater before your eyes.

When we want to take a horseback ride, we have a choice of at least half a dozen trails, and every time we take a ride, we see something different, discover something new about the ranch.

When I was still in the acting business, I'd bred my horse, Baby, with a dapple gray thoroughbred stallion and she produced a dapple gray mare I named Nancy D because I was courting someone by that name. After Baby got up in years, I trained Nancy D and she became a wonderful hunter and jumper; later on, I bred Baby once more and got a beautiful black colt I named Little Man because he was very large.

I lost Nancy D when she was sixteen with an extreme case of gastroenteritis and then I switched to Little Man, the son of Baby.

A friend of ours, a surgeon who also likes to ride, once told me that when he had a really difficult operation ahead of him, he always got up early in the morning and went for a ride and when he was finished, he felt ready for the operation.

Riding has the same kind of effect on me.

Since the day we bought the ranch, if Nancy or I wanted to think something out, there's been no better place to do it than Rancho del Cielo.

As I've said, there's something about the wild scenery and serenity at the ranch and having a horse between my knees that makes it easier to sort out a problem. I think people who haven't tried it might be surprised at how easily your thoughts can come together when you're on the back of a